Healthy Living for Older Adults

V2.1 · Health Basics + Personal Notes + Interest Workshops



> **How to use this workbook** Start with the page that matters to you today. Read a few points and write down your questions. This is not a book to memorize; it is a practical guide for everyday life.

Less dense text, more ideas you can see and use.

Page guide



Start with what matters most to you

Health toolkit Body changes p.3 | Chronic conditions p.5–7 | Medicines p.8–10 | Food p.11–12 | Movement p.13–14 | Home safety and emergencies p.15–17 | Mood and memory p.18–19 | Checkups and appointments p.20–21

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A simple rhythm for each class

01 Look at the illustration

Find the small picture that shows the topic.

02 Choose one useful idea

You do not need to remember everything. Write your questions on a notes page.

03 Try one small change at home

Share it with a friend, classmate, instructor, or someone you trust. See whether it works for you.

Emergency signs Sudden chest pain, severe shortness of breath, facial drooping, weakness on one side, trouble speaking, or confusion? Call your local emergency number right away.



Changes with age do not always mean illness

Some changes happen gradually, such as needing more light to read, lighter sleep, or slower walking. Forgetting a name and remembering it later does not by itself mean illness. Notice whether changes are becoming more frequent or affecting everyday activities.

Things you can observe Occasional tiredness, a brief memory lapse, or gradual changes in vision or hearing. Note when it happens, how long it lasts, and what you were doing.

Consider making an appointment Memory, mood, walking, appetite, or daily tasks are getting harder over time; weight keeps dropping; or sleep problems affect daytime life.

Seek urgent help for sudden changes Sudden chest pain, severe shortness of breath, facial drooping, one-sided weakness, trouble speaking, or confusion. Call your local emergency number. Do not wait for symptoms to pass.

Tell your clinician what has changed

Instead of saying only “I have not felt well,” try: “Twice this month I had to stop and rest on a short walk. It is happening more often than before.” Specific examples can help a clinician understand what is going on.



My body changes: a note to bring to an appointment

Write down the one change that concerns you most. A few notes can make it easier to explain what has been happening.

The change I noticed: _____

About when it started: _____

How often / how long it lasts: _____

A daily activity it affects: _____

A question I want to ask: _____

> **Example** “Twice last week I felt short of breath near the end of a short walk. Rest helped, but it is happening more often.” This is more useful than saying only “I do not feel well.”

If you notice the emergency signs on the previous page, call your local emergency number instead of stopping to fill in this page.



Managing a long-term condition: look for patterns

High blood pressure and diabetes may not cause obvious symptoms. Do not judge control by how you feel today, and do not change a dose based on one reading.

Checking blood pressure at home

01 Sit quietly for about 5 minutes

Support your back, keep both feet flat, and stay quiet during the measurement.

02 Place the cuff on your bare upper arm

Support your arm at about heart level. Follow the device instructions.

03 Repeat and record

Wait about 1 minute between readings. Record the date, time, and numbers, and bring them to your appointment.

> **For blood sugar, record when you tested** Fasting, after a meal, and bedtime readings are not directly comparable. Note the time and its relation to meals; follow your care plan for how often to test.

> **Targets are personal** A clinician can set goals based on your health, age, risk of low blood sugar, and other conditions. Do not copy someone else’s target.



Two emergencies to recognize

Persistent chest pressure or pain If it comes with sweating, nausea, or shortness of breath, call your local emergency number immediately. Do not drive yourself or wait for your next appointment.

Remember FAST for possible stroke

F Face

Ask the person to smile. Does one side of the face droop?

A Arms

Ask the person to raise both arms. Does one arm drift down or feel weak?

S Speech

Ask the person to repeat a simple sentence. Is speech slurred or hard to understand?

T Time: call for help

Note when symptoms began. Do not give food, drink, or medicine unless emergency professionals tell you to.

Watch for low blood sugar Shaking, sweating, a fast heartbeat, or weakness may be warning signs. Follow the personal plan made with your clinician. If someone is unconscious or cannot swallow, do not put food or drink in their mouth; call for emergency help.



Bone and joint pain deserves attention

Osteoporosis can weaken bones without early symptoms. Height loss, a new stoop, or ongoing back pain are reasons to ask a clinician whether a bone-density test is appropriate. A fall can cause a fracture, so take it seriously.

> **Protecting your bones** Foods such as dairy or fortified alternatives, beans, tofu, and leafy greens can provide calcium. Activity and safe time outdoors may also help. Ask a clinician before taking calcium or vitamin D, especially if you have kidney disease or kidney stones.

Notice how joint pain changes

- **Note when it hurts**

Tell your clinician whether stiffness is worse in the morning, pain increases with activity, or rest helps.

- **Move gently; do not push through pain**

Gentle movement or warmth may feel helpful for some people. Seek medical advice for a hot, swollen joint or sudden severe pain.

> **Pain medicines need care** Some pain medicines can affect the stomach, kidneys, or blood pressure. Ask a clinician or pharmacist about options for ongoing pain.



Before taking a medicine, check the label

Many people use prescription and nonprescription medicines, vitamins, supplements, or traditional remedies at the same time. Different packaging does not always mean different ingredients. Bring an up-to-date list to appointments.

01 Check the person’s name and the medicine name

Do not identify a pill by its color or shape alone. Ask a pharmacist if the label is unclear.

02 Check the dose, timing, and instructions

Instructions may differ for before meals, after meals, or bedtime. If unsure, ask rather than guess.

03 Do not double a dose after a missed dose

What to do depends on the medicine. Check its instructions or ask a clinician or pharmacist.

04 Note any new symptoms

Report a rash, significant dizziness, weakness, a fall, or a change in alertness. Breathing trouble or a severe allergic reaction needs urgent help.

> **Do not stop, increase, or switch a medicine on your own** Even if you feel better, discuss changes with the prescriber.

Notes / quick reminders



My medication list

List prescription and nonprescription medicines, vitamins, supplements, and traditional remedies. Update the list whenever something changes.

Medicine 1

Name / what it is for: _____

How much and when: _____

Medicine 2

Name / what it is for: _____

How much and when: _____

Medicine 3

Name / what it is for: _____

How much and when: _____

Questions for my clinician or pharmacist

Could any ingredients be duplicated or interact?

_____

What should I do if I miss a dose? _____

Can this tablet be split, crushed, or changed to another form?

_____

> **Storing medicines** Follow the label and keep the instructions. Do not split or crush special-release tablets unless a pharmacist or clinician says it is safe.



Supplements are not a substitute for treatment

Supplements cannot replace prescribed treatment for conditions such as high blood pressure or diabetes. Whether calcium, fish oil, or vitamins are suitable depends on your diet, health, and other medicines.

> **Pause when you hear claims like** “Cures everything,” “You do not need a clinician,” “Buy today or lose your chance,” or “Stop your current medicine.” These are not reliable medical advice.

1 Do not send money or share one-time codes

If a stranger asks you to transfer money or install unfamiliar software, end the call and verify independently.

2 Write down the product name

Check it with a trusted person, clinician, or pharmacist before buying.

3 Use an official source

Check medicines and supplements through a recognized regulator or public health agency; do not rely on a seller’s verbal promise.

My plan for handling a health-related sales pitch

When I am unsure, I will ask: _____

Someone I can check with: _____



Make room for variety at meals

You do not need a “miracle food.” Choose a variety of staple foods, vegetables and fruit, and protein foods that fit your culture, budget, appetite, and health needs. Notice changes in appetite, weight, chewing, or swallowing.

Staple foods **Rice, bread, oats, corn, potatoes, or other grains and starchy foods**
Choose portions that fit your appetite and health needs.

Protein foods **Beans, lentils, fish, eggs, dairy or fortified alternatives, tofu, or lean meat**
Choose different options across the week. If chewing is difficult, ask about softer textures.

Vegetables and fruit **Choose different colors and types when available**
The right amount and preparation can depend on your health and care plan.

> **If you have a health condition, avoid one-size-fits-all diets** Food needs can differ with high blood pressure, diabetes, kidney disease, and other conditions. Avoid extreme diets, cutting out whole food groups, or taking large amounts of supplements without advice.

> **Fluid needs are individual** Drinking smaller amounts through the day may be comfortable. If a clinician has asked you to limit fluids because of a heart or kidney condition, follow that plan.

Notes / quick reminders



What did I eat today?

No need to count calories. Recall the kinds of foods you ate and choose one small change to try tomorrow.

Staple food today: _____

Vegetables / fruit today: _____

Beans, fish, eggs, dairy, tofu, or meat today:

_____

Something I noticed

Any change in appetite, chewing, or swallowing?

_____

A question for my clinician or dietitian:

_____

> **Tell a clinician promptly** Frequent coughing while eating, trouble swallowing, a major drop in appetite, ongoing weight loss, repeated vomiting, or a sudden change in bowel habits should not be addressed only by changing your diet.

One small change I might try tomorrow:

_____



Movement and recovery: safety first, then routine

Choose activity that fits your strength, balance, pain, and health conditions. Exercise does not need to leave you exhausted. After surgery, illness, or a recent fall, ask a health professional what is suitable.

Walking **A stroll, walking indoors, or gentle dancing**
Start at a comfortable pace for a short time and build a routine you can maintain.

Strength **Try sit-to-stand movements beside a stable support**
Move steadily and keep breathing. Stop and ask for advice if knee or back pain increases.

Balance **Shift your weight while holding a sturdy chair**
Clear the area. Do not close your eyes or practice on a slippery surface.

> **Stop if you notice** Chest pain, severe shortness of breath, dizziness, a racing heartbeat, or a sudden increase in pain. Seek help if symptoms are severe or do not settle with rest.

Notes / quick reminders



My weekly movement log

A short note is enough: what you did, for how long, and how you felt. Set goals with a health professional if needed.

Monday Activity: _____ About how long: _____ How I felt: _____

Tuesday Activity: _____ About how long: _____ How I felt: _____

Wednesday Activity: _____ About how long: _____ How I felt: _____

Thursday Activity: _____ About how long: _____ How I felt: _____

Friday Activity: _____ About how long: _____ How I felt: _____

Saturday Activity: _____ About how long: _____ How I felt: _____

Sunday Activity: _____ About how long: _____ How I felt: _____

> **Three ways to reduce fall risks** Clear clutter from walkways; turn on a light when getting up at night; use a non-slip bath mat and check that grab bars are secure. Wear well-fitting shoes with good grip.

One place at home I can make safer:

_____



A quick home safety check

Start with the route you use most. You do not have to change the whole home at once. Ask someone you trust to walk through with you if vision, hearing, or balance has changed.

- ☐ **Walkways** Could cords, curled rugs, or clutter cause a trip?
- ☐ **At night** Are slippers within reach? Is the path to the bathroom well lit?
- ☐ **Bathroom** Is the floor slippery? Are grab bars and non-slip mats secure?
- ☐ **High shelves** Can everyday items be moved within easy reach?
- ☐ **Kitchen** Is it easy to forget a stove, appliance, or kettle is on?

One change to make today Tell someone you trust about the spot that feels least safe, and start there together.



If something happens: call for help first

> **If there is an emergency** Check that the area is safe. Call your local emergency number and give the location, symptoms, start time, and a call-back number. Follow the dispatcher's instructions. Do not move or give medicine unless instructed.

Possible stroke

Remember FAST: check the face, ask the person to raise both arms, listen to their speech, and call your local emergency number if you notice a sudden problem.

Do not give food, drink, or medicine. Note when the symptoms began.

Phone and online safety

- **A caller asks you to transfer money**

Hang up. Call the organization using a number you already trust, or ask someone you trust to help verify.

- **Someone asks for a code or bank details**

Do not share them, open unfamiliar links, or install software at the caller's request.

- **If you live alone**

Arrange a regular check-in with someone you trust. Make sure they know whom to contact in an emergency.

Notes / quick reminders



My emergency and contact information

Keep this page somewhere you and a trusted person can find it. Review it together from time to time.

Emergency contact name / phone: _____

My address (to give the emergency dispatcher):

_____

Health conditions / allergies responders should know:

_____

Where I keep my current medicine list:

_____

When calling for emergency help, share

1 Your exact location, including building, room, and a nearby landmark.

2 What happened, when it began, and whether the person is awake and breathing normally.

3 A call-back number. If possible, ask someone to meet responders at the entrance.

In an emergency, call your local emergency number. Online searches are not a substitute for urgent care.



Mood, sleep, and memory deserve care

Retirement, health changes, grief, or a change in surroundings can affect mood. Feeling sad sometimes does not automatically mean illness. Ongoing low mood, loss of interest, or major changes in sleep or appetite are reasons to talk with someone and seek professional support.

> **When to seek support** If low mood or anxiety lasts for about two weeks and affects sleep, eating, interests, or daily life, contact a primary care clinician or mental health professional.

> **Sudden confusion needs prompt medical attention** A rapid change in awareness, behavior, or speech—especially with fever, a fall, or a new medicine—should not simply be blamed on age.

Keep a few familiar routines

- **Stay in touch**

Choose a day to call a friend or take a walk together.

- **Keep doing things you enjoy**

Singing, gardening, reading, games, and learning a song can be adapted to your energy.

- **Keep important things easy to find**

Use a regular place for keys, a calendar for appointments, and an up-to-date medicine list.

> **Memory practice is not a guarantee** Reading, social connection, and activities can support engagement, but no single exercise can guarantee prevention of dementia.

Notes / quick reminders



My mood and connection menu

Write down someone you might contact and one small thing that helps you feel comfortable. Leave out private details if you prefer.

Someone I would like to contact: _____

Call / meet / do something together:

_____

One small thing that helps me relax:

_____

An activity I might try this week: _____

Talking with someone about support

> **Start with what matters to you** "What worries me most is…" "I would like to keep doing this myself…" "I would like someone I trust to come with me…"

> **How someone can help** Listen first, then decide together how to handle appointments, medicine reminders, or household tasks. Avoid criticism or taking over every decision.

If you think about harming yourself, tell someone you trust or a health professional right away. You do not have to handle it alone.



A checkup is not better just because it has more tests

Screening depends on age, health history, family history, and previous results. Ask the clinic whether to fast and what to do with regular medicines. Do not stop a medicine unless a clinician tells you to.

- **Before the visit**

Bring your health records, previous results, and current medicine list. Bring identification or insurance details if they are used where you live.

- **During the visit**

Mention past conditions, operations, allergies, and recent changes in how you feel.

- **Reviewing results**

An out-of-range mark is not a diagnosis by itself. Ask how it fits with your symptoms and earlier results.

- **Follow-up**

Add follow-up dates to a calendar. Seek care for ongoing symptoms even if a previous checkup was normal.

> **Preventive care after age 65** Ask your local primary care clinic or public health service which checkups and preventive services are recommended for you. Guidance varies by country and personal health.



My appointment notes

Write the three most important things first. If time is short, start with the problem that concerns you most.

The main thing I want help with today:

_____

When it started and how it has changed:

_____

Medicines / supplements I use: _____

Three questions I want to ask

1. _____ _____
2. _____ _____
3. _____ _____

Before I leave, check

☐ I know how to take my medicine. ☐ I know when to follow up. ☐ I know what symptoms need earlier help.

> **Coverage and referrals** Insurance coverage, referrals, and clinic services vary by location and plan. Check with your local health service or insurer.

Learn something new.
Make room for more joy.



The goal of these workshops You do not have to master something in one class. Take one photo, arrange one flower, or check one piece of information. That counts.

Phone photography · Flower arranging · AI and information checking · Container gardening · Hand lettering · Music



Phone photography: make the subject clear

Start by getting a clear photo; editing can come later. Choose something you enjoy: a flower, a cup of tea, a portrait, or the light outside your window.

1 Clean the lens and hold steady

Use both hands. Rest your elbows lightly against a table or your body if that helps.

2 Look at the light and background

Light from the front or side can help. If the background feels busy, take a step or move closer.

3 Choose one main subject

You do not need to include everything. Place the subject near the center or a little to one side.

4 Check the photo

Make sure it is clear and the subject is not blocked. Retake it if you like.

> **Try this** Take three photos of one flower: a wider view, a close-up, and one from a different angle. Choose the one you like best.



Photo editing: make small changes and keep the original

Photoshop or a phone photo editor works in a similar way. Make one small change at a time, compare before and after, and undo anything you do not like.

- **Crop**

Remove distracting edges, but keep a person’s head and the main part of a flower in the frame.

- **Brighten**

If a photo is dark, raise the brightness a little. Keep details visible.

- **Adjust color**

Make small changes to warmth or saturation so flowers and food still look natural.

- **Save a copy**

Keep the original photo. Ask before sharing a photo of someone else.

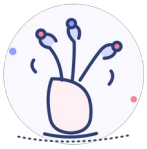
My photo notes

What I photographed: _____

What I like about this photo: _____

An angle or light I want to try next time:

_____



Flower arranging: choose a focal flower, then look at the whole

Flowers do not need to be expensive. Choose a stable vase, colors you like, and some open space. Notice the direction of the stems and make small adjustments.

01 Choose a stable vase

Add water and check that the vase will not tip easily.

02 Place the focal flowers

Choose one to three flowers and decide how tall and which way the arrangement should face.

03 Add supporting flowers and leaves

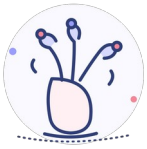
Look from different sides. If it feels crowded, remove one stem and compare.

04 Trim and care for the arrangement

Remove leaves below the waterline. Check the water and change it as needed for the flowers.

> **Comfort and safety** Point scissors away from yourself. Ask for help trimming stems if your hands are uncomfortable. If fragrance or pollen bothers you, choose low-scent flowers or focus on color and shape.

Notes / quick reminders



My flower-arranging plan

Think it through before you begin. Your notes do not need to look like a drawing.

Flowers / leaves I would like to use:

_____

Where I might place the focal flower: left / center / right

_____

Colors I would like to use: _____

The shape of my vase: _____

Sketch a simple arrangement

○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

> **After arranging** Is the vase steady? Can you see the focal flower? Do you like the colors? Write down one thing you are happy with.



Radio, websites, and AI: check before you act

Radio, websites, and AI can explain ideas or help organize questions, but they cannot examine you. Check advice about symptoms, medicines, or treatment with a clinician or pharmacist.

- **Check the source**

Who published it: a recognized health service, a medical organization, or someone selling a product?

- **Check the date**

When was it posted? Has it been updated?

- **Check the purpose**

Is it explaining health information, or urging you to buy, transfer money, or install an app?

- **Take questions to a trusted source**

Save the claim and where you found it. Ask a clinician, pharmacist, or public health service.

> **A prompt you can try** “Explain this health topic in plain language. Tell me what needs a clinician’s judgment. Do not diagnose me or tell me to stop or change a medicine.”

> **Protect your privacy** Do not upload identity documents, bank details, passwords, one-time codes, or an unedited medical record. Check an AI service’s privacy settings before use.

Notes / quick reminders



Checking a health claim

Write down one piece of advice you heard, then find a reliable source to check it.

The advice I heard or read: _____

Who shared it / where I found it: _____

Date: _____

Who I can ask to verify it: _____

What I learned / what is still unclear:

_____

> **A quick reminder** If the source is unclear, pause. If the information is old, check for an update. If someone urges you to buy or stop a medicine, ask a health professional.



Container gardening: begin with one easy-care plant

You do not need many tools. Notice the light, airflow, and space where you live, then choose a plant that fits. You might start with a familiar herb such as mint, basil, or scallions.

1 Choose a spot

Notice how much sun it gets and whether it gets wet in the rain. Keep the pot stable and out of walkways.

2 Choose one manageable plant

Ask a garden-center worker or instructor what suits your light. Start with one small plant.

3 Check the soil and leaves

Feel whether the soil is dry and follow the plant label for watering. Use a pot that drains well; do not let water sit in the tray.

4 Observe once a week

Look for new leaves, color changes, and soil moisture. Note when you watered and find a routine that works.

> **A safety note** Do not eat an unfamiliar plant or use an ornamental plant as medicine. Keep soil, fertilizer, and pruning tools away from children and pets.

Notes / quick reminders



My plant observation card

One note a week is enough. A small change is worth noticing.

Plant name (ask an instructor if unsure):

_____

Where I keep it: _____

Light / weather today: _____

The last time I watered it: _____

A change in the leaves or new growth:

_____

Sketch one leaf you noticed today

_____

_____

_____

_____

> **Next week I will look for** Has a new leaf grown? Does the soil dry quickly? Observe before changing how you care for the plant.



Hand lettering: make a small card of your own

You do not need perfect handwriting. Choose a pen that feels comfortable, sit with relaxed shoulders, and write slowly. Copy a short message to make a greeting card or bookmark.

1 Choose a short message

For example, “Wishing you a peaceful day” or a kind note for someone you care about.

2 Write it large first

Try it once on scrap paper with a thicker pen. Leave some space between letters and words.

3 Add one small drawing

Try a flower, a leaf, or a few stars. Keep it simple; the card does not need to be full.

4 Share it or keep it

Add the date and your name. Give it to someone or keep it in your notebook.

> **Keep your hand comfortable** Take short breaks or use a thicker pen if your fingers or wrist tire easily. Stop if writing hurts.

Notes / quick reminders



My greeting-card draft

Try a few words here first. You choose who it is for and what you want to say.

Who I might give it to: _____

One thing I would like to say: _____

Colors I might choose: _____

Write or sketch below

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

One thing I like about it _____



Music and memories: listen and note how it feels

Choose a familiar song, local music, a faith or community program, or a radio show. Listen at a comfortable volume. A familiar sound can be a pleasant part of the day and a way to start a conversation.

1 Choose a familiar sound

It could be a song you have enjoyed for years, local folk music, or a favorite radio program.

2 Set a comfortable volume

It should be easy to hear. If you need the volume very high, check the device or headphones.

3 Notice one detail

Write down a lyric, a melody, or a place or person it brings to mind.

4 Share it if you like

Tell a classmate, friend, or family member when you first heard it and what you remember.

> **Protect your hearing** Avoid listening through headphones at high volume for long periods. Ask a clinician about ongoing ringing in the ears or difficulty hearing conversations.

Notes / quick reminders



A sound I remember

You do not need to write a full story. A few words are enough.

Song / program I heard today: _____

A sound detail I liked: _____

A time or place it brings to mind: _____

Someone I might share it with: _____

Draw a small mark for this sound

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

If you would like Ask someone to listen to a familiar song with you and share what each of you remembers.



A four-week plan: change one small thing at a time

Keep the goal small enough to begin. Review it later and decide whether it suits you.

My goal (for example, take a short walk twice a week):

_____

The day I plan to begin: _____

Something that might get in the way:

_____

Someone who could join or remind me:

_____

What I would like to review after four weeks:

_____

One note each week

Week 1: _____

Week 2: _____

Week 3: _____

Week 4: _____

> **No need to blame yourself** If it did not happen, see whether the goal was too difficult or the timing was not right. Make it smaller and try again.



Class notes

Write down a question for the instructor or one idea you would like to remember.

01 _____

02 _____

03 _____

04 _____

05 _____

06 _____

07 _____

08 _____

09 _____

One thing for next time _____



Sources and how to use this workbook

This workbook shares general health information, not a personal diagnosis or treatment plan. Guidance and services vary by location and may change. For questions about medicines, symptoms, food, fluids, or activity, ask a health professional who knows your situation.

World Health Organization (WHO): Ageing and health · Open source

WHO: Healthy diet · Open source

WHO: Physical activity for older adults · Open source

WHO: Mental health of older adults · Open source

National Institute on Aging: Taking medicines safely as you age · Open source

CDC: Heart attack signs and symptoms · Open source

CDC: Stroke signs and symptoms · Open source

> **Emergency reminder** Sudden chest pain, severe shortness of breath, facial drooping, one-sided weakness, trouble speaking, or confusion? Call your local emergency number. Do not wait for an online reply.

May this workbook be a small helper in daily life: easy to find when you need it, with space to write questions and try something new.